



Ruby

△ Mid-20th century ruby earrings set with 18-karat gold and diamonds

Ruby is the red variety of the mineral corundum, and its colour seamlessly picks up where pink sapphire stops. Only darker stones are generally called rubies, but the distinction between ruby and pink sapphire can be a matter of opinion. Ruby is sometimes tinged with purple, and the most valued colour is known as pigeon-blood red. It has been mined from the gravels of Sri Lanka since at least the 8th century BCE, the subject of speculation from its earliest days. Ancient Hindu and Burmese miners thought pale pink sapphires were unripe rubies.

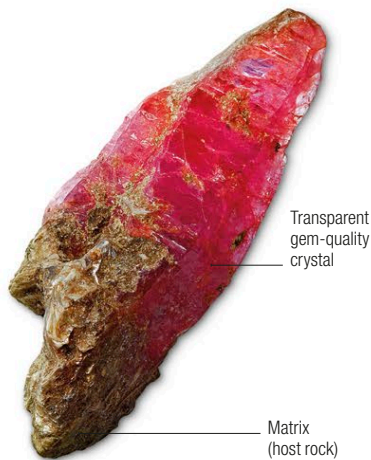
Specification

Chemical name	Aluminium oxide	Formula	Al_2O_3
Colour	Red	Structure	Trigonal
Hardness	9	SG	
RI	1.76–1.78	Lustre	Vitreous
Streak	Colourless		
Locations	Myanmar, Sri Lanka, Nigeria, Thailand, Australia, Brazil, Kashmir, Cambodia, Kenya, Malawi, Colombia, USA, and more		

Rough



Raw ruby | This gem-quality crystal has the horizontal striations that indicate changes in its growing environment. Ruby ranges from deep cochineal like this to pale rose-red.



Tapering crystal | This prismatic, gem-quality ruby crystal of good colour retains a segment of the matrix in which it grew at the base.



Crystals in rock | Displaying the gemstone in its natural state, this specimen of rock groundmass is host to a number of prismatic Kashmir ruby crystals.

Cut



Brilliant cut | The faces of this round brilliant ruby illustrate one of the four Cs (colour, clarity, cut, carats) that contribute to a gem's quality – in this case, a perfect cut.



Star ruby | The high-domed oval cabochon, good, intense colour, and clearly defined star markings place this star ruby among the finest examples.

Ruby is the solitary and glowing eye which dragons and wyverns carry in the middle of their foreheads

Bishop **Marbodius**
(11th century)